Introduction to Case Studies

Welcome to our exploration of Case Study Methodology. Imagine you want to understand something not by looking at surface-level statistics of a million people, but by diving incredibly deep into just one. A Case Study is an in-depth investigation of a single 'unit'—this could be one person, one group, or a specific event.

Unlike broad surveys, this method is designed to explore the underlying principles and causes of a phenomenon. It is a descriptive and exploratory analysis that seeks to understand the 'why' and 'how' rather than just the 'how many."

We refer to this as an "Empirical Inquiry." "Empirical" is a fancy word that simply means we are learning by looking at real-world evidence and direct observation, rather than just guessing or relying on pure theory. We are looking for the hidden rules that govern a specific situation.

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The Real-Life Context

To understand this method, we must contrast it with a science lab. In a lab, scientists try to control everything and strip away the environment. Case Studies do the exact opposite. They investigate a phenomenon within its real-life context.

We believe that you cannot truly understand a person or an event if you remove them from their environment. The context—the noisy street, the family dynamic, the workplace pressure—is actually part of the story.

By studying the subject in their “natural habitat,” we can see how external variables influence behavior. This allows us to catch the implications of variables that a controlled experiment might completely miss because it stripped them away.

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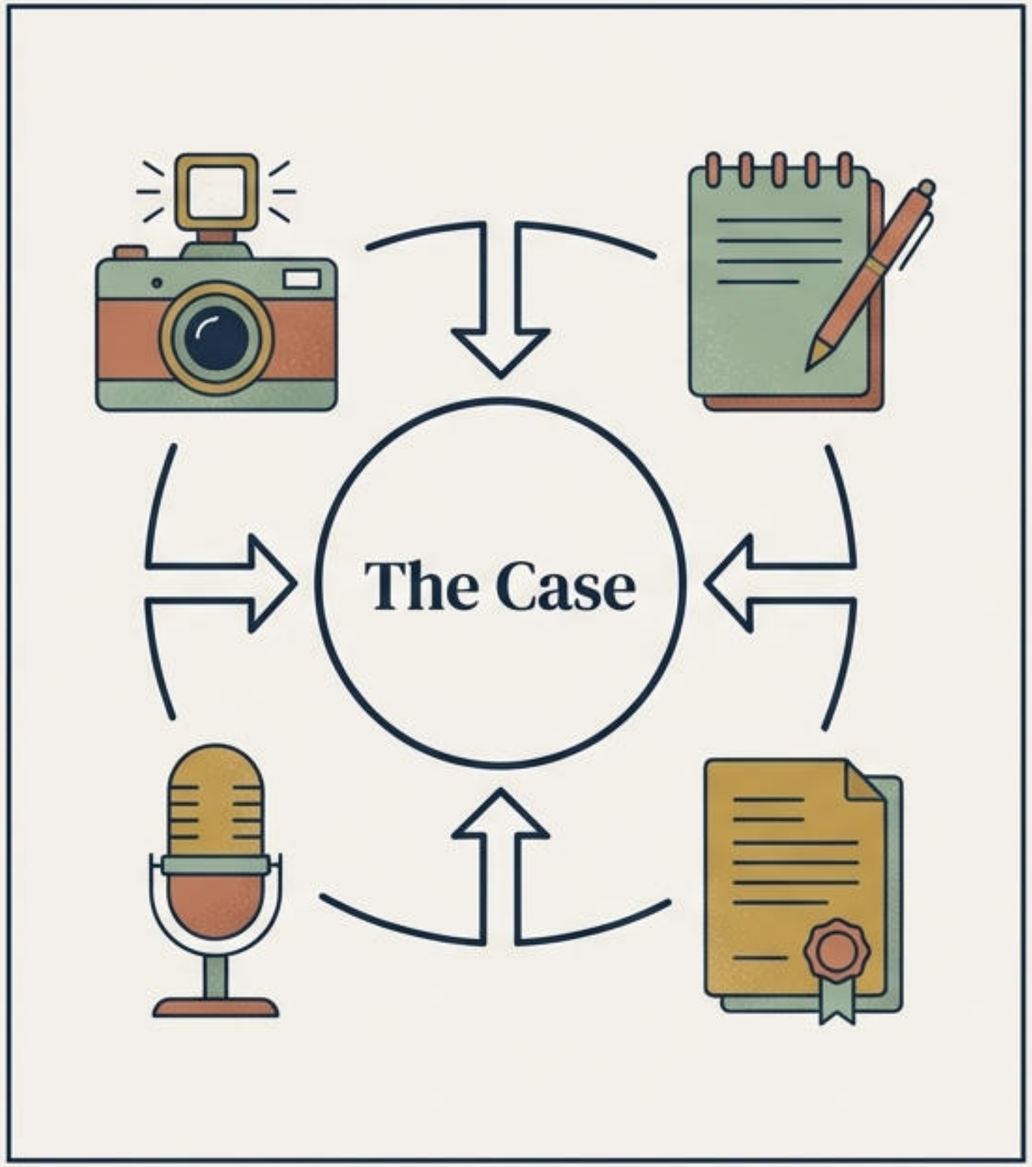

Multi-Faceted Understanding

Because real life is messy and complex, relying on just one source of information isn't enough. Case Studies recognize that there are many variables operating at once. To capture this, we need a "360-degree view."

This means we rely on multiple sources of evidence. We don't just ask the subject questions; we might also observe them from a distance, read their diaries, interview their friends, and look at official records.

Ideally, this method generates a multi-faceted understanding. Think of it like a detective building a case: a fingerprint is good, but a fingerprint *plus* a witness statement *plus* a security video is undeniable. This creates a "integrated totality" of the subject.

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Holistic Analysis

You will often hear the word “Holistic” in this course. This means we study the person, group, or institution as a whole system, rather than breaking them down into tiny, disconnected parts.

Whether we are analyzing decisions, periods, policies, or institutions, we look at them as an integrated web. For example, if we study a school’s failure, we don’t just look at test scores. We look at the teachers, the parents, the funding, and the neighborhood history all together.

By treating the social unit as a “totality,” we can understand the complexity of factors that are operative within it. We are trying to see the big picture and how every small piece relates to every other piece.

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Mixed Methods Approach

One of the superpowers of the Case Study is that it is a “Mixed Methods” approach. This means it can blend numerical data (Quantitative) with descriptive stories (Qualitative).

While the numbers might tell us “what” is happening, the descriptive data helps us explain “why.” According to researcher Robert Yin (2009), this combination allows the study to explain, describe, illustrate, and enlighten the reader all at once.

The quantitative evidence adds precision, while the qualitative evidence adds richness and detail. Together, they solve the puzzle in a way that neither method could achieve on its own.

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Characteristics: Intensity & History

Let's look at the specific characteristics that define this method. First, the study is 'Intensive.' We select a single unit and study it comprehensively. We aren't skimming the surface; we are digging deep.

Second, this method often requires a 'Longitudinal' approach. 'Longitudinal' simply means watching something happen over a very long period of time. We don't just take a snapshot of today; we want to see the movie of the subject's life.

By extending the study over time, we can ascertain the 'natural history' of the unit. This helps us see how they evolved into who they are today, ensuring we have enough information to draw the correct inferences (conclusions).

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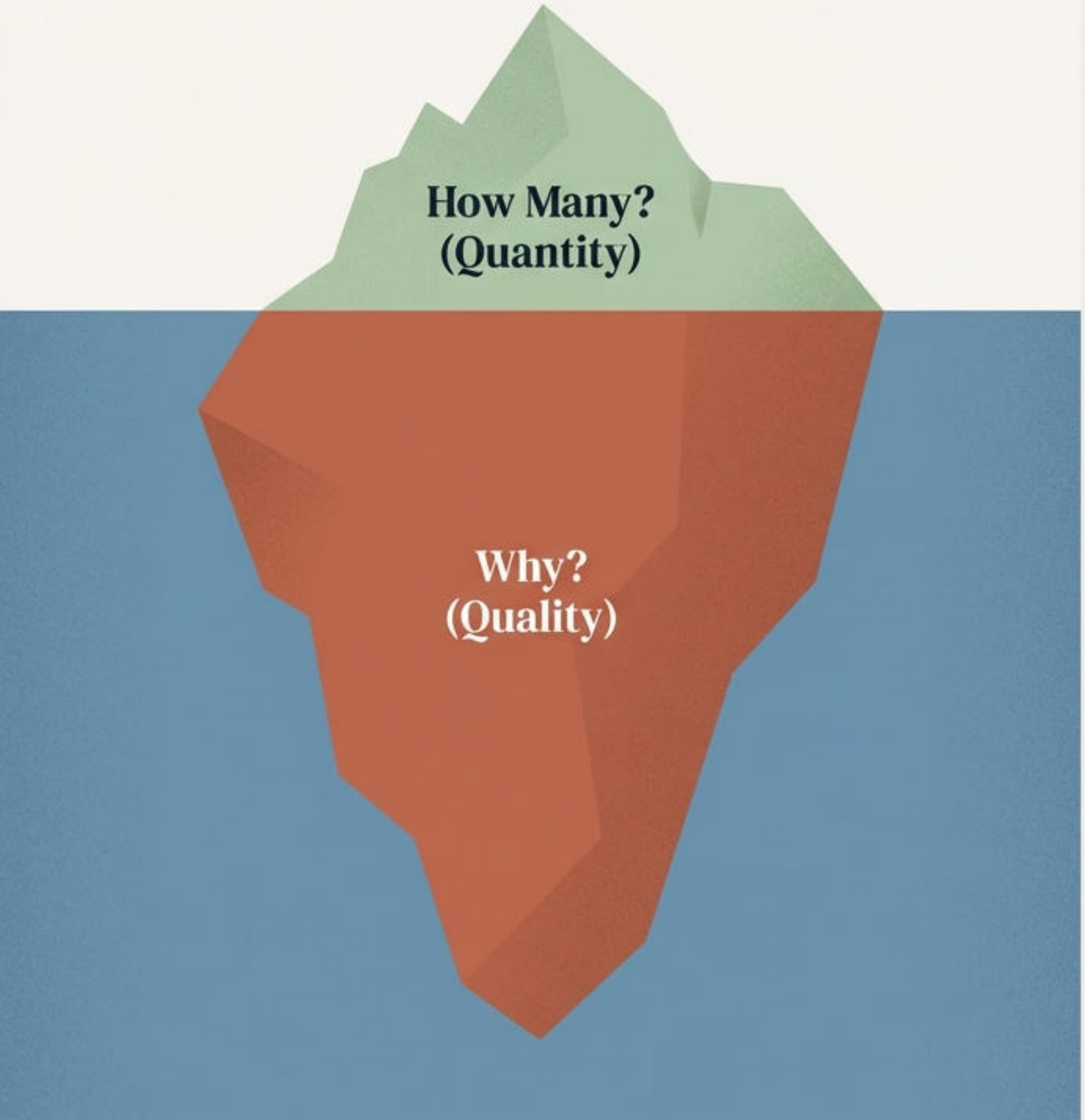

Characteristics: Complexity & Quality

Third, our approach focuses on 'Quality' over quantity. Mere numbers are not enough. We make every effort to collect information concerning all aspects of the subject's life to deepen our perception.

For example, if we are studying a criminal, a survey might just ask 'How many crimes have you committed?' A Case Study, however, asks 'Why?' We peep into the factors and pressures that forced him to commit those crimes.

This gives us a clear insight into life that numbers cannot provide. The objective might be not just to punish, but to understand the human being enough to suggest ways to reform them.

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Characteristics: Relationships & Hypotheses

We also look for “Causal Factors.” This means we try to figure out the mutual inter-relationships—basically, what causes what? We want to know exactly which events triggered a specific behavior.

We study the behavior pattern directly, not through an abstract filter. We want to see the subject in action to avoid the errors that come from guessing or indirect assumptions.

Finally, these deep studies result in “Fruitful Hypotheses.” A hypothesis is a smart, educated guess that can be tested later. Case Studies help build these theories, making our generalized knowledge of social science richer and more accurate.

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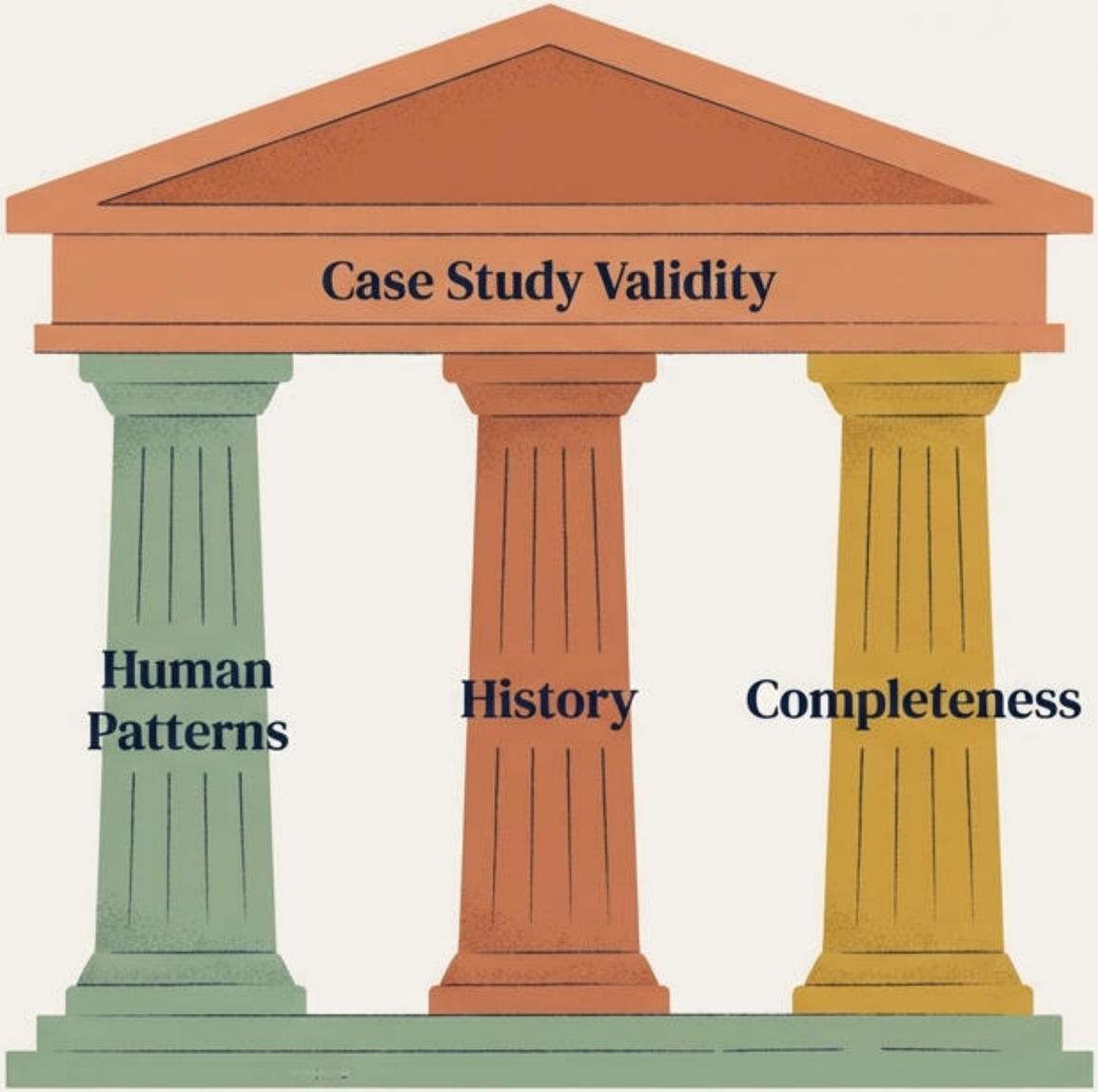

Core Assumptions in Tiempos Headline

Before we start a study, we have to agree on three core assumptions. First, we assume there is a uniformity in basic human nature. Even though situations vary, humans generally follow recognizable patterns of behavior.

Second, we assume that “History Matters.” We cannot understand the present without studying the “natural history” of the unit concerned. Where you came from dictates where you are.

Third, we assume the need for a “Comprehensive Study.” We believe that to find the truth, we must study the unit totally. Leaving out parts of the story will lead to an incomplete or false conclusion.

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The 6 Steps: Design Phase

Now, how do we actually do this? The University of Texas suggests six steps to ensure success. Step 1 is to determine your research question. Case studies usually start with a “How” or “Why” question to define exactly what phenomenon we are investigating.

Step 2 is purely about design. You must choose your cases carefully and decide *beforehand* how you will gather data. Will you use interviews? Video? Diaries?

You must also decide which techniques you will use to analyze that data. A well-designed study considers all options early on so that you don’t get lost later.

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The 6 Steps: Prep & Fieldwork

Step 3 is Preparation. You are about to collect a massive amount of information. You need to plan how to deal with large sets of data so you don't become overwhelmed. Formulate good questions and anticipate how you will interpret the answers.

Step 4 is "Fieldwork." This means going out into the real world (the field) or the lab to collect the data.

As you collect data, you must maintain an organized database and keep good field notes. If you are disorganized here, your final results will be unreliable.

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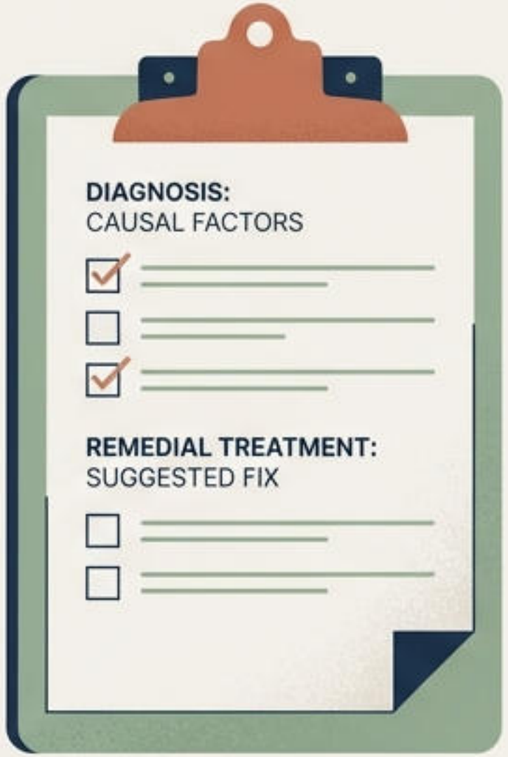

The 6 Steps: Analysis & Reporting

Step 5 is Analysis. We look for the "Diagnosis"—identifying the causal factors that created the problem. This often leads to "remedial treatment," where we suggest a fix or therapy based on what we found.

Step 6 is the Follow-up and Reporting. If a treatment was applied, we need a follow-up program to see if it actually worked. Did our solution fix the problem?

Finally, we prepare the report. This communicates our findings to the world, adding our new knowledge to the scientific community.

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Advantages: Depth & Rarity

Why choose this method? First, it provides “Rich Detail.” We can collect data with a depth that other experimental designs simply cannot match. It gives us the full, colorful picture.

Second, it is perfect for “Rare Cases.” Sometimes, we want to study a phenomenon that is so unique—like a specific brain injury—that we can’t find a large group of people who have it.

In these instances, where large samples aren’t available, the Case Study is the only way to gain scientific knowledge. We can conduct experiments within this single case to adapt ideas and produce novel hypotheses for the future.

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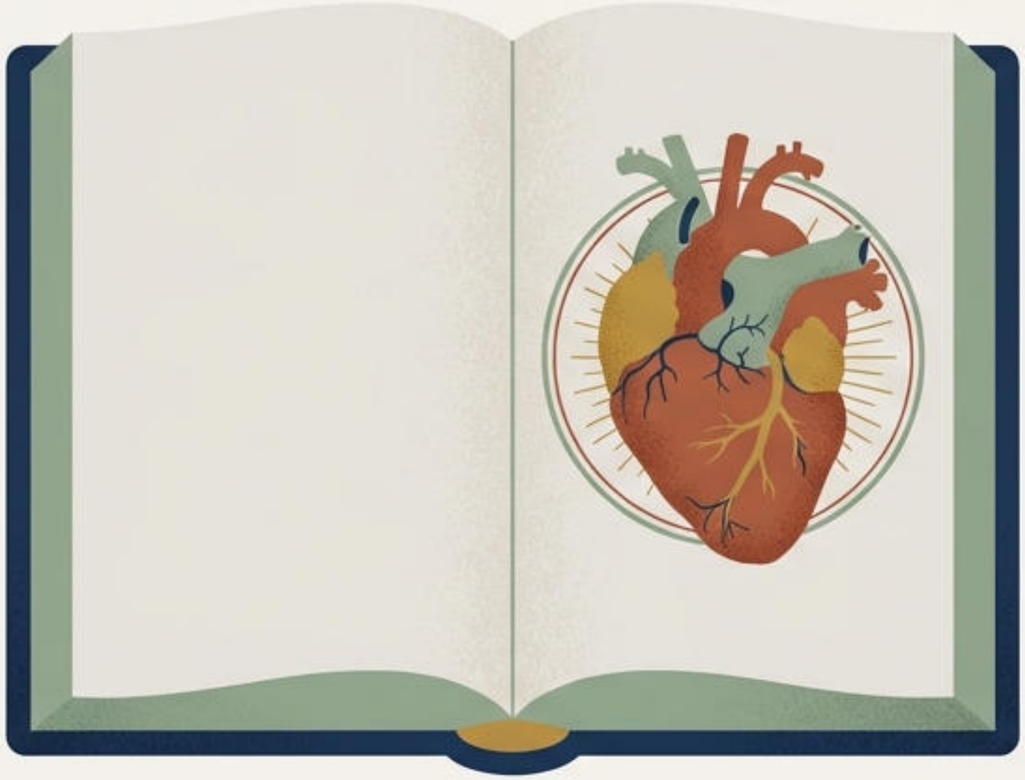

Advantages: Personal Insight

Beyond just facts, this method gives us a “Clearer Insight” into life. It deepens our perception of what it means to be human.

A researcher can obtain an “enlightened record” of personal experiences. This reveals the subject’s “inner strivings”—their secret motivations, frustrations, and the hidden forces that drive them to act the way they do.

This type of information is invaluable for therapeutic purposes (helping people heal) and even administrative purposes (making better management decisions), as it explains the behavior patterns we see on the surface.

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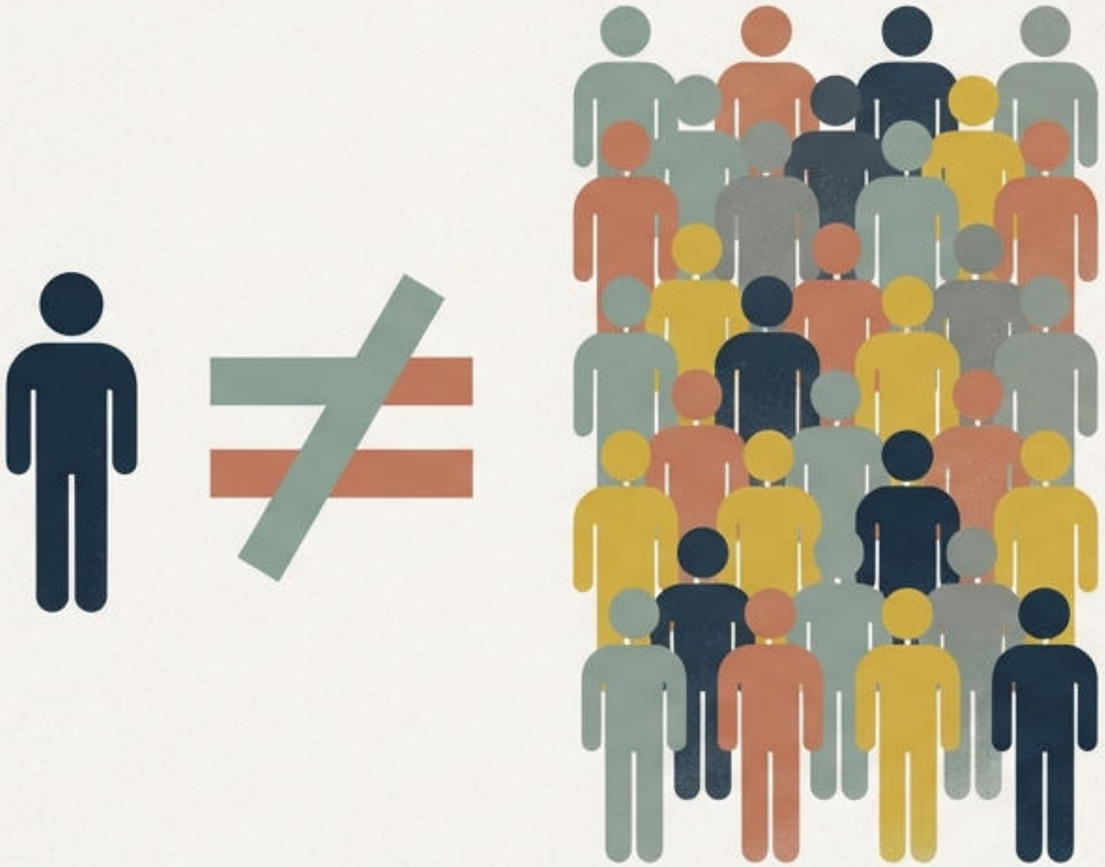

Disadvantages: Generalization

However, we must be honest about the limitations. The main criticism is the problem of “Generalization.” Just because something is true for one person, does it mean it is true for the wider population?

Often, the answer is no. Data collected from a single case may not be relevant to everyone else. This is the “N=1” problem (where N stands for the number of participants).

Because of this, critics argue that the method isn’t always useful for creating universal laws of behavior. It tells us a lot about *one* person, but maybe not much about *people* in general.

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Disadvantages: Subjectivity & Bias

Another major risk is “Subjectivity” and “Bias.” Since there is usually only one experimenter collecting the data, their own feelings and opinions can enter the collection process.

A famous example is Sigmund Freud. He used case studies (like Little Hans) to prove his theories, but many argue he wasn’t being scientific—he was just seeing what he wanted to see to prove his point.

This makes it hard to draw definite cause/effect conclusions. If the researcher overestimates their own knowledge or lets their personal feelings influence the data, the study becomes unreliable.

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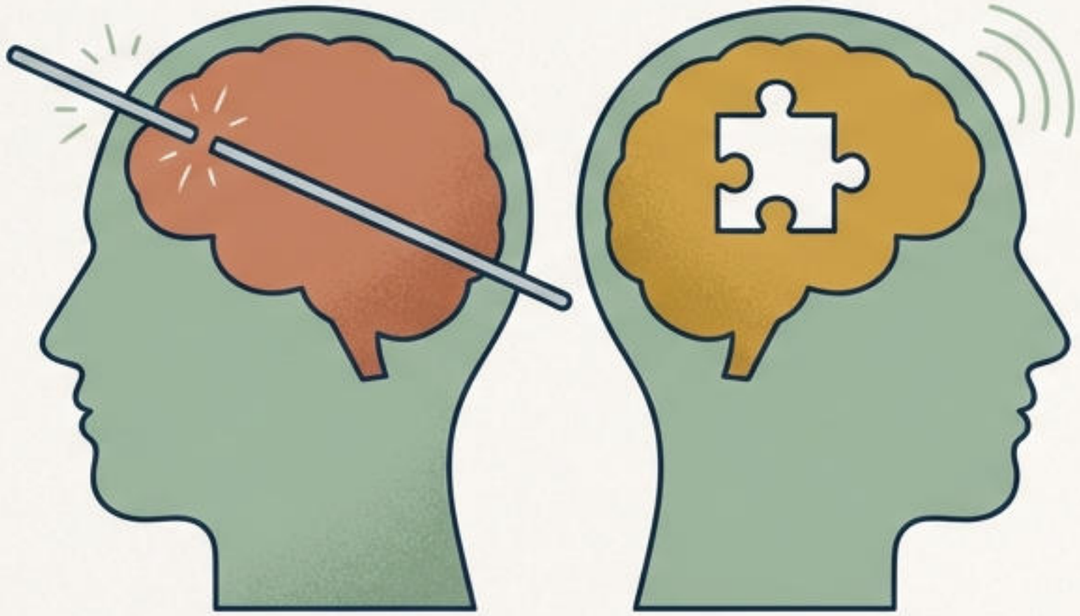

Famous Examples: The Classics

Let's look at the "Classics" that shaped psychology. First is **Phineas Gage (1848)**. He was a railroad foreman who survived a metal rod passing through his brain. By studying how his personality changed after the accident, we learned that the frontal lobe controls social behavior.

Then there is **Patient H.M.** (Henry Molaison). After brain surgery to stop epilepsy, he lost the ability to form new memories.

Studying H.M. was pivotal. It taught scientists the difference between short-term and long-term memory systems. These insights would have been impossible without studying these specific, tragic cases.

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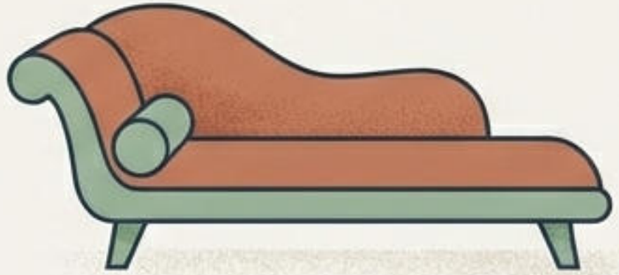

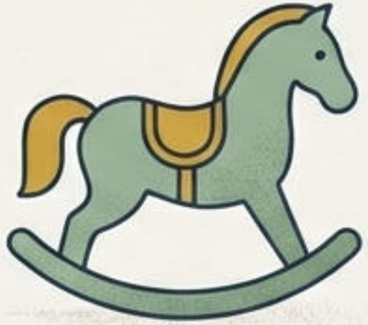

Famous Examples: Development & Therapy

We also learned about development from **Genie (1970s)**, a girl subjected to severe isolation until age 13. By studying her, researchers tried to answer if language could still be learned after missing critical growing periods.

In the world of therapy, **Anna O.** is famous. Her treatment by Josef Breuer for 'hysteria' led to the invention of the 'talking cure'—the foundation of modern talk therapy.

Finally, Freud's study of **Little Hans**, a boy with a phobia of horses, was used to explore childhood fears and family dynamics. These cases show how individual stories shape our understanding of the human mind.

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Tips for Writing Case Studies

If you are asked to write a Case Study, take the advice of Charles Warner. First, keep your audience in mind and keep the jargon (technical words) to a minimum. If you must use hard words, explain them clearly.

Second, **Tell a Story**. Make your characters and situations real. Set the scene, describe the frustrations, and use dialogue to make the characters come alive. Don't just list facts; engage the reader.

Finally, don't analyze *while* you tell the story. Present the scenes logically step-by-step, and save the analysis for the end. Leave the reader with a clear picture of the problem and the lingering question: "What is to be done now?"

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Summary for Revision

Definition

A Case Study is an empirical, holistic inquiry into a single unit (person/group) within its real-life context. It uses mixed methods (Qualitative + Quantitative) to find underlying principles.

The Process

Remember the 6 steps—❓1. Define Question (How/Why), ❓2. Select Cases, 📦3. Prepare, 4. Collect Data (Fieldwork), 🔭5. Analyze/Diagnose, 📈 6. Report & Follow-up.

Pros vs. Cons

✅ The method is excellent for “Rich Detail,” “Rare Cases,” and “Insight.”

❌ However, it suffers from “Bias,” “Subjectivity,” and the inability to “Generalize” findings to the whole population.

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